



Going to Extremes: How Like Minds Unite and Divide

By C.R. Sunstein; New York: Oxford, 2009, 199 pp.

Going to Extremes is a meta-analysis of the social phenomenon of group polarization. Sunstein includes original research with sources from various disciplines to describe and explain how some types of groups tend to shift toward extreme viewpoints. The book consists of five chapters, an appendix of research summaries, with cited references in endnotes.

Sunstein, a Harvard law professor, continues his keen and timely discourse on how people make decisions. We are influenced by those we associate, and this association has a ripple in politics and policy. An opportunity for introspection is presented as we are challenged to evaluate how we came to our own beliefs and values, and a better understanding is formed when we are reminded that there is a dark side to freedom of thought. This was certainly an informative, though alarming book.

In the first chapter Sunstein discusses the general phenomenon of group polarization. Sunstein demonstrates that various groups such as consumers, political groups, and business organizations tend to radicalize under certain conditions. Like-minded people deliberating within homogeneous groups will tend to shift to extreme positions.

Deliberation is a key component in the polarizing process. Interaction between people with similar views will reinforce these views, creating a feedback loop or “echo chamber.” More homogeneous groups have greater potential for polarization. The information shared in these groups is predominately one-sided, and there are social pressures to conform to perceived group norms.

For example, panels of federal court judges exhibit more extreme voting patterns when the panels consist of solely Democrat or Republican appointees. Mixed panels will tend to issue more moderate opinions, except on certain issues such as abortion where judges have strong convictions. Another example concerns jury rewards and punishments. A jury that is predominately lenient or severe will tend to get more so after deliberations.

In each example the pre-deliberation median of the dependent variable is the best predictor of which direction the group view will move. The amount of diversity within the group predicts the intensity of the shift. Homogeneous groups will move to greater extremes than more diverse groups. The relationship holds true in various cultural, behavioral, and cognitive domains.

In the second chapter Sunstein explores why and when like-minded people go to extremes. The flow and control of new information is the most significant factor in the development of

extreme viewpoints. Sharing a viewpoint with others makes a person confident in a position, leading to entrenchment. Reputational factors also are important, as members will naturally seek approval from others in their reference group.

Certain positions on an issue carry with them inherent rhetorical advantages in deliberation. For example, a politician may adopt a 'tough on crime' stance to avoid the rhetorical disadvantage of appearing 'weak' on crime, regardless of the underlying logic. A shared sense of outrage may make an opposing position seem socially indefensible on any terms.

Members of deliberative groups are prone to psychological biases. Opposing views are commonly dismissed as propaganda, while supporting views are accepted uncritically. Another bias comes from the need to avoid the cognitive dissonance of being 'wrong' about an issue. Sunstein cites the classic Milgram and Zimbardo experiments on authority and obedience to illustrate how dramatically individual behavior can be shaped by group processes.

The Internet community has had a large effect on shaping the discourse within groups. Although the medium has the potential to disseminate a wide variety of information, the tendency is for users to narrow their consumption to specialized sources. The narrow range of information consumed is especially pronounced in blogs and chat rooms.

Extremism spreads through groups by social cascades, where individuals go along with what they think others are thinking. Informational cascades are the result of the cumulative effect of information, which gives the content an intuitive credibility. The efficiency of various media in disseminating information makes these cascades especially dramatic. Another type of social cascade is reputational, where the need for social approval may stifle moderate or dissenting views.

The third chapter deals with social movements. When like-minded people are isolated in an enclave, they can develop a shared sense of identity and common grievances. Ethnic movements are often reputational in character, as members choose to identify with ethnic roots based on social cohesion. The genocide of the Balkans is an example of this sort of reputational cascade in action. Sunstein attributes ethnic hatred as an effect, rather than a cause, of polarization.

Conspiracy theories are another example of social movements fueled by polarization through informational cascades. One factor that encourages the spread of conspiracy theories is a "crippled epistemology" where ignorance and thinking errors combine with limited informational availability to create a fertile breeding ground for irrational beliefs.

Terrorism is perhaps the most important social movement to consider in light of group polarization. Sunstein argues that terrorism is not primarily an outgrowth of poverty, low education, or mental illness, but instead is a more generalized group process. Terrorist movements thrive best in totalitarian states, where information is strictly controlled by a distrusted government. This is fertile ground for extremists to use isolation, informational cascades, and reputational cascades to indoctrinate members.

The fourth chapter concerns the prevention of extremism. The first means of prevention is rooted in traditionalism. Radical movements are least likely to emerge from traditional, conservative groups by definition. A second source of prevention is rooted in the moral philosophy of consequentialism. Polarization is much less likely in groups that critically predict the likely outcomes of their actions instead of relying on emotion and social pressures to make decisions. A third means of prevention is structural, consisting of checks and balances built into the system.

The final chapter of the book deals with positive aspects of extremism. The same group dynamics that lead to polarization can lead to constructive change. One example of a positive outcome is that of civic activism, which generally requires a polarization between progressive and conservative interests to effect social change.

One key factor that limits extreme polarization is the level of diversity in and between groups. Even though homogeneous groups will tend to radicalize, diversity between different groups will serve as a check. In a federalist system, for example, individual states, which may be homogeneous, are balanced within a diverse whole.

Sunstein utilizes an interdisciplinary method in his analysis, combining philosophical, sociological, and psychological perspectives. The whole combines into a useful meta-analysis of a complex process. The suggestions for prevention would prove difficult to operationalize, although Sunstein does provide theoretical grounding.

The style, length, and presentation are appropriate for the general reader. Scholars will find a good introduction to the topic with references for further study. The material is particularly suitable to those interested in social psychology, policy studies, organizational behavior, and management. The book would make a good companion to Surowiecki's *The Wisdom of Crowds*.

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